Workout Plans as a Genre in the Fitness Community

Reading and writing are often associated primarily with academic environments such as classrooms, essays, and textbooks. However, literacy practices extend far beyond school and occur constantly in everyday social contexts. People regularly read and write in situations such as text messages, social media posts, personal planning documents, and online communities. These forms of writing are rarely random. Instead, they tend to follow recognizable patterns that allow people to communicate effectively within particular communities. Kerry Dirk explains that genres emerge because writers repeatedly encounter similar rhetorical situations, which leads them to develop familiar responses to those situations (Dirk 252). In other words, genres help writers understand what kind of text to produce when a particular problem arises. One everyday example of this process can be found in workout plans used within the fitness community. Workout plans function as a genre because they follow recognizable conventions such as structured organization, measurable training parameters, and progress tracking. These conventions shape how training information is communicated and determine whether a plan appears credible and useful within the fitness community.

Workout plans exist because individuals who train regularly face a recurring problem: how to organize their exercise to make progress, or whether or not their methods are truly effective. Whether someone's goal is increasing strength, building muscle, or improving athletic performance, they must decide how often to train certain muscles, what exercises to perform, and how to increase difficulty over time. Because this problem occurs repeatedly across fitness communities, writers have developed standardized ways of presenting training programs. Dirk

notes that genres help both writers and readers recognize what is expected in a particular situation and therefore guide how communication takes place (Dirk 253). In the case of workout plans, readers expect a clear structure that outlines exercises, sets, repetitions, and rest periods. Without these conventions, the document would be difficult to interpret or apply during training. The genre, therefore, makes the information more efficient and easier to understand for members of the community.

Genres also function as tools that allow people to act within specific situations. Rather than simply labeling types of writing, genres provide frameworks that help individuals accomplish their goals. Dirk argues that genres are “tools that help people to get things done” in recurring literary contexts (Dirk 254). A workout plan demonstrates this idea clearly. The purpose of the document is not simply to describe exercise but to organize physical activity in a way that leads to improvement. By structuring workouts and providing instructions, the genre transforms general advice about fitness into actionable steps. For example, a vague suggestion such as “train legs more often” does not give the reader enough information to act on. A workout plan, however, might instruct the athlete to perform four sets of six repetitions of squats with a specific rest period between sets. These precise instructions allow the reader to implement the training plan and measure progress over time.

Another important aspect of genre is the idea of rhetorical “moves.” According toJacobson, genres contain recognizable moves that writers use strategically to accomplish goals within a community (Jacobson et al. 4). These moves function as building blocks that make a genre recognizable to readers. In workout plans, several moves appear consistently. One common move is the inclusion of measurable training parameters such as sets, repetitions, and rest periods. These numerical elements allow readers to understand exactly how the exercise should be performed.

Another example is the organization of workouts across multiple training days. Many workout plans divide sessions into categories such as upper body and lower body or push and pull sessions. This structure allows readers to quickly understand how training should be distributed throughout the week. These moves signal that the text belongs to the genre of a workout plan and that the writer understands the unspoken rules of the fitness community.

The expectations surrounding workout plans are also connected to the broader idea of discourse communities. James Paul Gee explains that groups of people share ways of using language that reflect their values, goals, and social practices. He describes these systems of behavior as “identity kits” that members of a community use to act and communicate appropriately within that group (Gee 7). The fitness community has also developed its own vocabulary and communication styles that reflect its priorities. Terms such as sets, repetitions, rest periods, progressive overload, and one rep maximum are commonly used within this community. These terms appear frequently in workout plans and help signal that the writer is experienced with the practices of strength training. Someone outside the fitness community might find these terms confusing, but for experienced lifters, they provide important information about how a workout should be performed.

One example of this literacy practice can be seen in a workout plan I created for myself during the past several months while training. Because I train multiple days per week, I regularly write and review my workout plans to organize and track my training sessions. My most recent plan focused on improving strength in compound exercises, particularly the squat. In order to prioritize this goal, I structured the workout so that squats appear early in the session when my energy levels are highest. Each training day lists the exercises to be performed along with sets, repetitions, and rest periods. After each workout, I record the weight used and the number of repetitions completed. These notes allow me to measure progress over time and determine whether the program is effective.

The structure of my workout plan reflects a lot of the conventions found in programs online, but it is also shaped directly by how I train and what I have learned works best for me. I follow a structure built around repeating upper and lower sessions, organized as four days on, one day off, and then continuing the cycle. While this format is recognizable, the way I distribute volume is more personal. My upper days are longer, around seventeen sets, because of the number of muscle groups involved, while my lower days are closer to eight sets. Instead of doing multiple sets of the same exercise, I spread my volume across different movements that train the same muscle in slightly different ways. For example, rather than repeating pec flies, I will do one set of a standard fly and one set of a low-to-high cable fly to target different functions of the chest. This approach comes from my own experience prioritizing more complete muscular recruitment rather than simply repeating the same movement.

At the same time, the genre of a workout plan still shaped how I created and presented everything. I did not start with a blank structure but instead relied on formats I had seen online or discussed with other lifters, then adjusted them based on my understanding of fatigue and performance. The four days on and one day off structure comes from my awareness that fatigue builds across consecutive sessions and can limit how hard I can push in each workout. Including a rest day helps reduce that buildup and allows me to maintain intensity. I could rest more frequently, such as every other day, but that would shift the program toward a full-body style, which I have found creates too much fatigue within a single session. Because of that, I prefer an upper and lower split that distributes fatigue across days rather than concentrating it all at once. This shows how the plan still follows familiar conventions like sets, structure, and muscle group organization, while also being shaped by my own training philosophy and experience.

The effect of the artifact can also be analyzed through the lens of genre and discourse communities. Within the fitness community, workout plans are often shared and evaluated by others. Lifters frequently compare programs, offer advice, and suggest modifications based on their own experiences. As a result, credibility becomes extremely important. A plan that includes structured progression and measurable parameters is more likely to be taken seriously than one that provides only vague suggestions. When my workout plan adheres to the conventions of the genre, it signals to others that I understand the fundamental principles of training. Which means it's more likely that others can understand my training

The genre also influences how the writer interacts with the document. Because the workout plan includes measurable targets and recorded results, it functions as a system for monitoring progress. Each time I train, I compare my performance to previous entries in the plan. If the weight lifted increases or the number of repetitions improves, the program appears to be working. If progress slows, adjustments may need to be made. In this way, the genre does more than communicate information; it actively shapes behavior. The structure of the plan encourages consistency and motivates by making improvement visible over time.

Understanding workout plans through the lens of genre highlights how everyday writing practices are shaped by social and cultural contexts. The fitness community has developed conventions that make training programs readable and credible. Writers who participate in this community adopt these conventions because they allow information to be communicated efficiently. As Dirk explains, genres help writers respond to recurring situations by providing recognizable patterns that guide communication (Dirk 257). In the case of workout plans, these patterns allow athletes to organize training and track progress in a systematic way.

Analyzing this form of writing also demonstrates that literacy practices extend far beyond academic assignments. Workout plans may appear simple compared to essays or research

papers, but they still involve rhetorical decisions shaped by community expectations. Writers must determine how to structure information, what details to include, and how to present instructions clearly for readers. These decisions reflect the goals and values of the fitness community.

Ultimately, examining workout plans as a genre reveals how writing functions as a socially shaped activity. The conventions of the genre influence how the text is written, how it is interpreted by others, and how it affects the behavior of the people who use it. What may initially seem like a personal planning document is actually part of a broader system of communication within the fitness community. Recognizing these patterns demonstrates that literacy is not limited to academic settings but plays an important role in everyday activities where people use writing as a tool to organize knowledge and pursue shared goals.

Literacy Autobiography: Writing, Sponsors, and Identity

Before I signed up for this class, I thought of writing as something I only did for school. It was a way to get grades and complete assignments. I did not think of it as a way to express my thoughts and feelings. Writing was like a job. I did what I had to do. That was it. I would finish the work, follow the rules, and try to get the highest grade possible. Then I would move on to the next thing. Reading was pretty boring to me, too. It was something I had to do, not something I wanted to do. I did not really get into the

stories or care about what I was reading. I did it because I had to. When it came to talking, I usually only said what I thought was okay to say. I tried to sound smart and proper, like I was supposed to in school. I did not really talk about what I thought or felt unless it was something considered acceptable in a classroom. Writing, reading, and speaking were all things I did for school, like the class itself, the assignments, and the grades. I never really thought about how literacy is influenced by the people around me, the things I have access to, and the power that certain groups have. When I looked back on my own experiences with reading and writing, and when I learned about the ideas in this class, and when I talked to other people in the class, and when I read what authors like Deborah Brandt, Suzanne Kesler Rumsey, and Elizabeth Wardle had to say, I started to see that my own writing and writing in general are shaped by a lot of things that happened before I even took this class. It is a mix of things, like what schools expect from me, what my culture expects from me, and the opportunities I have had because of my education. Things such as my highly structured AICE coursework and writing classes, and my engineering courses that heavily relied on design notebooks, played a central role in shaping how I write today. Values of clarity, efficiency, and purpose were planted through coursework related to engineering, and I started to emotionally connect to my writing as my passion for engineering grew.

I remember when I was little and learning to read and write. This was something that happened mostly at school. My teachers were always there to guide me. I had to do worksheets and follow the rules. When I read something, it was so I could answer questions about it. I had to find the ideas and themes in the story. When I wrote, I had to make sure my sentences were correct. I had to put my ideas in order. I was allowed to

be creative, but only if I followed the rules. If I did something wrong, I might get in trouble. My school was very big on doing things a certain way. Reading and writing were not about expressing myself but about doing what my teachers told me to do. I learned that reading and writing were things that people judged when I was young. Reading and writing were not really about discovering things or saying what I thought and felt. People saw reading and writing as skills they could grade and evaluate. This was my idea of what reading and writing were all about.

As I progressed through school, this mindset intensified. Writing increasingly became associated with grades, rubrics, and rigid expectations. I learned quickly that success depended on following rules precisely. This environment encouraged a narrow variety of language that was formal, academic, and detached. Informal language, personal voice, or stylistic experimentation were often discouraged, reinforcing the idea that good writing meant conformity. Looking back, this shaped my belief that writing was something external to me, something performed rather than owned.

One of the most influential literacy experiences in my life was my junior year AICE writing class. This course acted as a powerful literacy sponsor, as Brandt would describe it. Brandt defines literacy sponsors as “any agents, local or distant, concrete or abstract, who enable, support, teach, model, as well as recruit, regulate, suppress, or withhold literacy” (Brandt 166). My AICE class both enabled and constrained my literacy development. On the one hand, it significantly improved my technical writing skills. On the other hand, it reshaped my emotional relationship with writing in ways that were limiting.

The course emphasized a rigid structure, strict tone, and near perfect grammar. Essays followed predetermined templates, and deviation often resulted in point deductions or failing grades. Writing became a process of fitting ideas into predefined molds rather than developing them organically. This aligns closely with what Wardle critiques as a misunderstanding of writing as a universal and transferable skill rather than a context dependent practice. As Wardle explains, “community, and activity, I suggest we would be remiss to focus solely on task or individual based conceptions of transfer with little regard for situation and activity. However, if we take context and activity into account, we have a much more difficult study.” (Wardle 69). In AICE writing, context and audience were flattened into a single standard. The AICE graders.

Brandt critiques this mechanical view of writing, arguing that it reduces literacy to “the most basic aspects of the apprentices’ literacy, especially their access to material production and the public meaning or worth of their skills. Paradoxically, even as the steam powered penny press made print more accessible (by making publishing more profitable), it brought an end to a particular form of literacy sponsorship and a drop in literate potential.” (Brandt 165). Over time, writing in this class became exactly that mechanical. I became efficient at producing academically acceptable essays, but the process felt impersonal and repetitive. Writing was no longer something I engaged with thoughtfully. It was something I executed. This experience fostered a distaste for writing that lingered long after the class ended, even as my technical proficiency improved.

My time writing engineering notebooks was really different from the types of writing I have done. When I was in engineering classes, the teachers did not care much about grammar or the quality of the writing. They cared about whether my ideas made

sense, whether I wrote down what I did, and whether my logic was sound. The point of writing was to get my ideas down to remember what I tried, what did not work, and what I did to fix it. This kind of writing was part of what I was doing, not something I did after I was done. Writing engineering notebooks was about solving problems and writing things down so I could remember them. The engineering notebooks and the writing that went into them were a part of my engineering classes.

Unlike the rigid expectations of AICE writing, engineering notebooks allowed flexibility and imperfection. Notes could be incomplete, messy, or even revised over time. The focus was on thinking through problems rather than presenting a finished product. This aligns closely with Rumsey's concept of heritage literacy, which emphasizes how individuals adapt literacy tools to fit their lived experiences and needs. Rumsey explains that literacy practices are shaped by "adoption, adaptation, and alienation" depending on how individuals relate to the tools available to them (Rumsey 295). In engineering notebooks, I adapted writing into something functional and personally meaningful rather than alienating.

This experience helped me start to take steps to reclaim writing as a tool rather than as a performance. Writing became something that supported my thinking instead of suppressing it. I was encouraged to use diagrams, annotations, and informal language, forms of multimodality that expanded what writing could look like. This multimodal approach reinforced the idea that literacy is not limited to traditional essays but includes visual, technical, and procedural forms of communication.

When I think about how I learned to read and write, I have to remember that I was lucky. I went to school and had good teachers. I was able to take classes and be part of programs like AICE and engineering that helped me learn how to write well. Not everyone gets to do these things. This makes me think about how my experiences fit into a picture of who gets access to good education and who does not. Literacy development is important to me. I know that literacy development was helped by the good schools I went to. My literacy development was also helped by the programs I was in, like AICE and engineering programs, which taught me how to write in various ways.

Brandt emphasizes that literacy sponsorship is often tied to economic and institutional power. My access to structured academic programs positioned me to succeed within certain literacy norms, even when those norms felt restrictive. At the same time, this privilege meant that I could eventually encounter alternative literacy practices, such as engineering notebooks, that challenged my earlier assumptions. Without access to these institutions, my literacy identity might have developed very differently.

Today, my feelings about writing are shaped by the difference between my two experiences with writing. I still think it is important to be clear, get to the point, and have a reason for writing, which is what I learned from AICE writing and engineering documentation. Now I understand how the situation affects my writing, and I am more willing to try different ways of writing. Writing is not something I do for fun, but if the situation is right, it can be useful, meaningful, and even make me feel good. I think writing is useful, and I like that writing can be meaningful. That is what I like about writing.

I now see myself as a writer who approaches writing as a tool rather than an art form. I believe this identity is not a limitation or necessarily negative, but a reflection of my literacy history. Understanding how my past experiences shaped this stance allows me to engage with writing more intentionally. Rather than rejecting writing outright, I can choose how and when to use it effectively. Regardless of my enjoyment or opinion about writing.

Together, my experiences in AICE writing and engineering courses illustrate how literacy sponsors and institutional contexts shape writing identity over time. Through Brandt's framework, my AICE class explains my emphasis on correctness and efficiency, as well as my initial alienation from writing. Through Rumsey's framework, engineering notebooks demonstrate how literacy can be adapted into a flexible, purposeful practice. Wardle's emphasis on context further clarifies why these experiences felt so different despite both involving writing. Reflecting on these frameworks has helped me understand that my relationship with writing is not accidental but the result of layered influences across time. Recognizing this has allowed me to move toward a more conscious and empowered literacy identity.

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Response Letter

Dear Professor Gonzalez,

I am writing this letter in response to the feedback I received on Major Assignments 1 and 2 throughout the semester. The comments from both my peers and my instructor have enabled me to identify the strengths and weaknesses in my drafts and to make more purposeful and meaningful revisions in my writing.. As Jillian Grauman explains, interpreting and acting on feedback is a learned skill that develops through practice and reflection (Grauman). I now recognize that feedback is not simply a list of corrections but a chance to engage more deeply

with my writing and its effect on readers. The revisions I have made are based on this understanding and represent measurable improvements to both assignments.

The most significant feedback I received on Major Assignment 1 addressed my use of MLA citations and integration of sources. My instructor observed that, although I referenced course readings such as Brandt and Rumsey, my citations were inconsistent and sometimes improperly formatted, resulting in a lower score on Trait 6. Peers also noted that some transitions between literacy events were abrupt, which made it difficult to follow the connection between my AICE experience and my engineering notebook experience. Furthermore, it was suggested that my thesis should be stated more clearly to help readers understand my central argument from the beginning. This feedback was notably valuable because it reflected the experiences of multiple readers, indicating that these were genuine comprehension problems rather than stylistic preferences.

In response to this feedback, I concentrated my revisions for Major Assignment 1 on three key areas. First, I systematically reviewed all in-text citations and the Works Cited page to correct formatting errors and ensure alignment with MLA 9th edition guidelines. For instance, I ensured that all citations included page numbers where available and that the hanging indent format was consistently applied. Second, I revised the transitional sentences between my two literary events to clarify the thematic connections. I added a bridge paragraph that explicitly links my experience in AICE writing to my transition to engineering notebooks, explaining how frustration in one context led to a more adaptable literacy practice in the other. Third, I rewrote my thesis to more clearly articulate the argument that my literacy experiences, formed by both

restriction and modification, this resulted in a writing identity grounded in purposeful clarity rather than expressive freedom. As Benjamin Miller argues in his essay on version history and revision, tracking changes in drafts enables writers to observe actual shifts rather than perceived improvements (Miller). This perspective encouraged me to treat revision as a deliberate process of comparison rather than depending exclusively on intuition.

For Major Assignment 2, the most significant feedback I received highlighted weaknesses in my MLA formatting and the extent of my analysis. My instructor noted that citations were often missing or incorrectly formatted, resulting in a 1 out of 5 score on Trait 5. Additionally, both the instructor and peers observed that, although I applied Dirk's genre framework, my analysis sometimes remained superficial, especially in the section discussing the discourse community aspects of my workout plan. The feedback showed that I needed to join theoretical terms such as lexis, rhetorical situation, and genre moves more explicitly to specific features of my artifact, rather than describing them in general terms.

In revising Major Assignment 2, I addressed these concerns directly. I revisited every source I cited and reconstructed the in-text citations and Works Cited entries to ensure proper MLA formatting. I also deepened my analysis by revisiting Gee's concept of identity kits and explicitly applying it to the vocabulary in my workout plan. For example, I added a paragraph that examines how terms such as progressive overload and one rep maximum function as both lexis and indicators of membership within the fitness discourse community, demonstrating an understanding of what Gee describes as the ways of using language that reflect a group's values and social practices (Gee 7). This revision transformed a general observation into a more

focused, theoretically grounded argument. Grauman's advice to identify the underlying purpose of feedback, rather than reacting emotionally, enabled me to view these comments as structural help rather than critique (Grauman). This change in perspective made the revision process more purposeful and less reactive.

Reviewing both assignments through the perspective of Taczak and Robertson's work on metacognition has been particularly insightful. They argue that reflective writing enables students to move beyond task completion and toward a more profound understanding of their own writing processes (Taczak and Robertson). This letter has served as a form of self-aware reflection for me. By articulating what I changed and why, I have gained greater clarity on how feedback and my developing understanding of effective writing have affected my revision decisions. Rather than viewing revision as a chore or a reaction to criticism, I now see it as an integral part of the writing process and an opportunity to refine my thinking and more closely align my work with my original goals.

The revisions I have made reflect my engagement with the feedback I received. These changes are substantive improvements that tackle the specific concerns raised by my instructor and peers. I hope this letter demonstrates both what I changed and why these changes strengthen both assignments.

Respectfully,

Owen Smith.

Revision Matrix

Assignment	Feedback Received	Revision Made
MA1 – Literacy Narrative	MLA citations are inconsistent and incorrectly formatted (Trait 6, 3/5)	Rebuilt all in-text citations and Works Cited from scratch using MLA 9th ed.
MA1 – Literacy Narrative	Transitions between literacy events felt abrupt	Added a bridge paragraph connecting the AICE and engineering notebook experiences thematically
MA1 – Literacy Narrative	The thesis was unclear and did not state a strong central argument	Rewrote thesis to clearly argue that restrictive and adaptive literacy experiences shaped a purposeful writing identity
MA2 – Socio-Cultural Analysis	MLA citations frequently missing or incorrect (Trait 5, 1/5)	Reconstructed all citations and Works Cited with correct MLA formatting
MA2 – Socio-Cultural Analysis	Analysis of discourse community features was too general; it lacked a specific theoretical application.	Expanded analysis to connect Gee's identity kit concept directly to specific vocabulary in the workout plan artifact

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